

What does a successful recurring-revenue business look like today?

What separates breakout subscription companies and where **AI creates the biggest opportunity**

MARKET INTELLIGENCE

EXECUTIVE BRIEFING



About the Data

What we analyzed, and why it holds up.

1,000

Recurring revenue businesses tracked

6

Key metrics per company (MRR, subscriptions, traffic, growth, category, model)



Goal: find what separates high-revenue businesses from the rest, using real benchmark data, not opinion.

Source: TrustMRR Benchmark Dataset

AI + SaaS Now Dominate Recurring Revenue

437 SaaS companies and **392 AI companies** together account for the vast majority of tracked MRR.

SaaS leads at **\$4.44M**, AI follows at **\$3.42M**—and the gap is closing fast.

📌 The winning formula: **AI delivered through a SaaS business model**

437

SaaS Companies

Largest category by count

\$4.44M

SaaS MRR

Top category by revenue

\$3.42M

AI MRR

Rapidly closing the gap

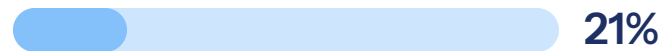
Revenue Comes from Subscribers, Not Traffic

One metric drives MRR above all others: subscription volume. Everything else is noise.



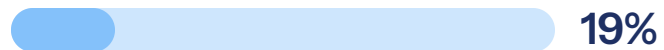
MRR vs. Active Subscriptions

The strongest correlation in the dataset
— by far



MRR vs. Domain Rating

SEO authority barely predicts revenue



MRR vs. Website Visitors

Traffic explains almost nothing about
MRR

What This Means

Stop over-investing in traffic. The highest-leverage bets are **conversion**, **retention**, and **growing paid subscribers**.

Top-of-funnel spend without monetization efficiency won't reach the winner's tier.

Revenue Is Concentrated Among Very Few Winners

Median MRR

\$282 — typical company barely breaks even

Average MRR

\$13,500 — skewed by a handful of outliers

Top 1% MRR

\$3.57M — elite winners capture nearly all revenue

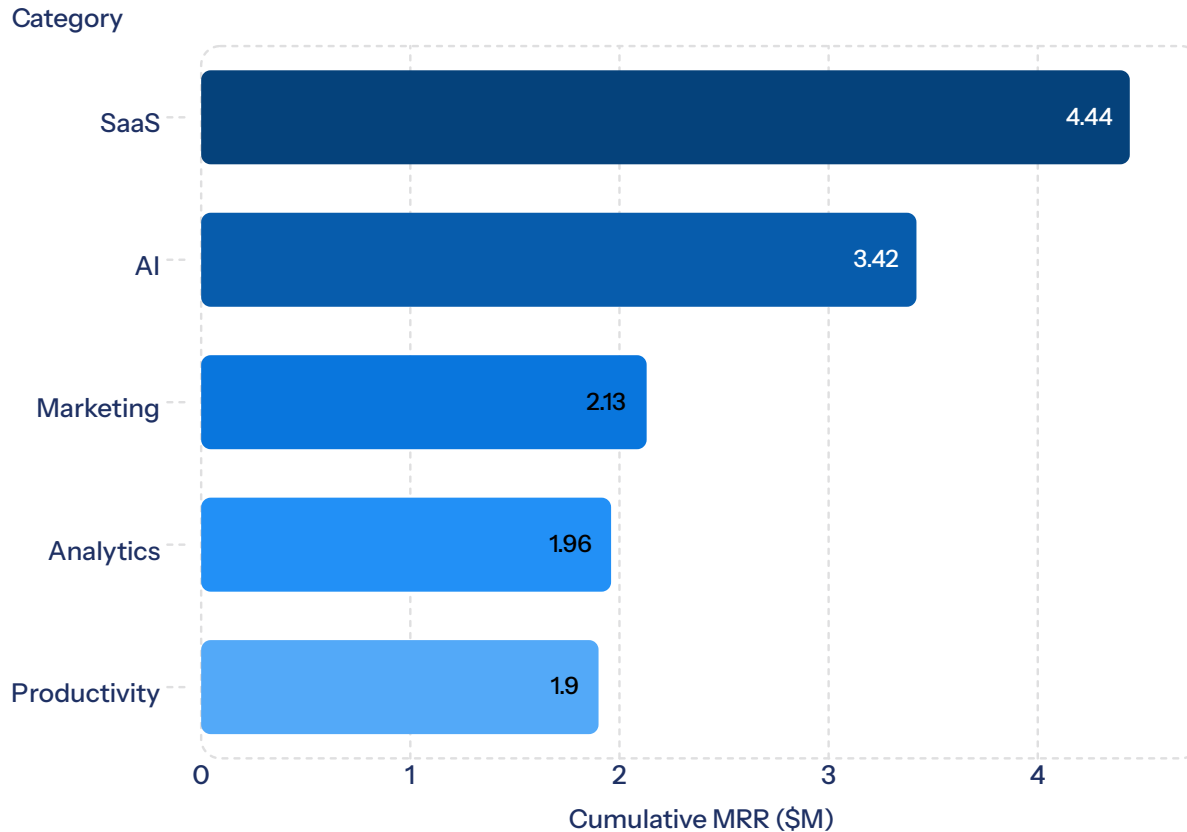
The **\$282 median** vs. **\$13,500 average** isn't noise—it's the market's structure. A few breakout companies pull the average up while most stay subscale.

The top 1% earn **12,700× more** than the median. Classic power-law dynamics.

❏ The hard part isn't launching, it's **scaling past the median**.

Winning Categories Monetize Better

The highest-MRR categories solve clear, recurring business problems—not just popular ones.



The top five categories: **SaaS, AI, Marketing, Analytics, and Productivity**; all solve high-value, evergreen business problems.

Opportunity lies where **recurring value is created**, not where the most products compete.

Three Key Takeaways

1

AI Is Now Table Stakes

40% of companies use AI. It's no longer a differentiator, it's expected.

2

SaaS Still Dominates

Recurring revenue outperforms every other model in scale and predictability.

3

Subscribers Predict Revenue. Traffic Doesn't.

Active subscribers correlate with MRR at **0.91**. Website visitors: **0.19**. Follow the signal.



Final Recommendation

Build. Convert. Retain. Win.

1

Build AI-Enabled SaaS Products

AI is table stakes, embed it in a subscription model

2

Convert and Retain Subscribers

Paid subscribers are the only metric that predicts revenue

3

Target High-Value Problems

Focus where willingness to pay is structural and durable



The path to the top 1% is a monetization strategy, not a traffic strategy